

Examining Spiritual Abuse, Racial Trauma, and Psychological Distress Among African American Muslims

Introduction

African American Muslims may experience intersecting forms of harm that stem from both racial discrimination in broader society and spiritually grounded abuse within religious or community contexts. Experiences of racism, Islamophobia, and misuse of religious authority may contribute to adverse psychological outcomes, yet limited quantitative research has examined how these factors jointly influence mental well-being among African American Muslims.

The present study examines the relationships among spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress in a sample of African American Muslims living in the United States. Specifically, this study investigates whether spiritual abuse and racial trauma are independently associated with psychological distress and whether racial trauma intensifies the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. Understanding these relationships may inform clinical practice, community interventions, and scholarly discussions related to trauma, religion, and race.

Research Questions

This study addresses the following research questions:

RQ1: What is the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress among African American Muslims?

RQ2: What is the relationship between racial trauma and psychological distress among African American Muslims?

RQ3: To what extent does racial trauma moderate the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress among African American Muslims?

Method

Participants and Procedure

Participants completed an anonymous online survey examining experiences related to spirituality, racial discrimination, and mental well-being. Eligibility criteria required

participants to be at least 18 years of age, self-identify as Muslim, reside in the United States, and report experiences of racial or religious discrimination and/or emotional or mental harm from Muslim leadership, community members, or family.

Participants provided informed consent prior to beginning the survey. The questionnaire required 25 minutes to complete and included demographic items followed by multiple self-report measures assessing spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress. Only fully completed questionnaires were included in the final analytic sample.

The final sample consisted of 128 African American Muslim participants.

Measures

Demographic Variables

Participants reported demographic information including age, racial or ethnic identity, gender identity, relationship status, highest level of education completed, employment status, Muslim affiliation, and approximate annual household income. Demographic variables were numerically coded for analysis. Descriptive statistics were used to summarize sample characteristics.

Spiritual Abuse

Spiritual abuse was assessed using 27 items (Q11–Q37) measuring excessive monitoring, misuse of religious authority, suppression of questioning, and emotionally harmful religious practices within Muslim leadership or community contexts. Responses were recorded on a Likert-type scale. A composite spiritual abuse score was computed by calculating the mean of the relevant items, with higher scores indicating greater perceived spiritual abuse.

Racial Trauma

Racial trauma was assessed using 13 items (Q38–Q50) measuring experiences of racial discrimination, vigilance, fear, and emotional distress related to racism. Items reflected both interpersonal and societal racialized stressors. A composite racial trauma score was computed by averaging responses across the relevant items, with higher scores reflecting greater racial trauma.

Psychological Distress

Psychological distress was measured using 17 items (Q51–Q67) assessing symptoms such as depression, anxiety, emotional dysregulation, hypervigilance, and trauma-related

reactions. Responses were recorded on a Likert-type scale. A composite psychological distress score was computed by calculating the mean of these items, with higher scores indicating greater psychological distress.

Data Preparation

The dataset was screened for completeness prior to analysis. Only cases with fully completed demographic and survey responses were retained. Consent-related content and identifying information were removed. Survey items were numerically coded and imported into statistical software. Composite variables for spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress were computed using mean scores of their respective item sets. Predictor variables were mean-centered prior to moderation analysis, and an interaction term was computed.

Descriptive Statistics and Demographic Characteristics

Descriptive statistics were computed to summarize the demographic characteristics of the sample. The final analytic sample consisted of 128 African American Muslim participants residing in the United States.

Age.

Participants' ages ranged across adulthood, with a mean age of 30.0 years ($SD = 1.10$). No missing age data were observed.

Gender Identity.

A majority of participants identified as male (58.6%), while 40.6% identified as female.

Racial or Ethnic Identity.

Most participants identified as Black or African American (84.4%), consistent with the study's target population. The remaining participants identified as another racial or ethnic background (15.6%).

Relationship Status.

Most participants reported being married (71.1%). Additional relationship statuses included single (13.3%), divorced (10.2%), and other statuses (5.4%).

Educational Attainment.

Participants reported relatively high levels of education. Over half of the sample (53.9%) reported completing college-level education, and 21.9% reported post-college education.

Employment Status.

Most participants were employed (79.7%), followed by students and individuals reporting other employment statuses, indicating a largely economically active sample.

Household Income.

Household income varied across participants, with the largest proportion (58.6%) reporting annual household incomes above \$50,000.

Variables confirming Muslim identity and U.S. residence showed no variability because all participants met eligibility criteria and were therefore excluded from further descriptive analyses.

Descriptive Statistics for Study Constructs

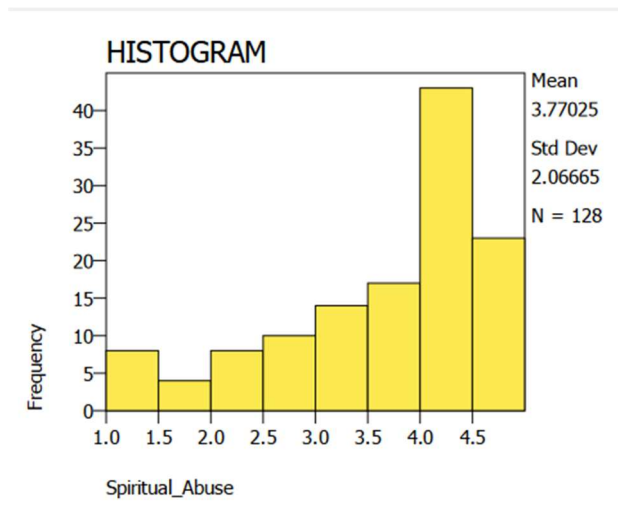
Descriptive statistics were calculated for the three composite study variables. Means, standard deviations, and ranges indicated adequate variability across spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress, supporting their suitability for correlational and regression analyses.

Distribution of Key Constructs

Histograms were generated for spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress to examine score distributions and assess assumptions of normality.

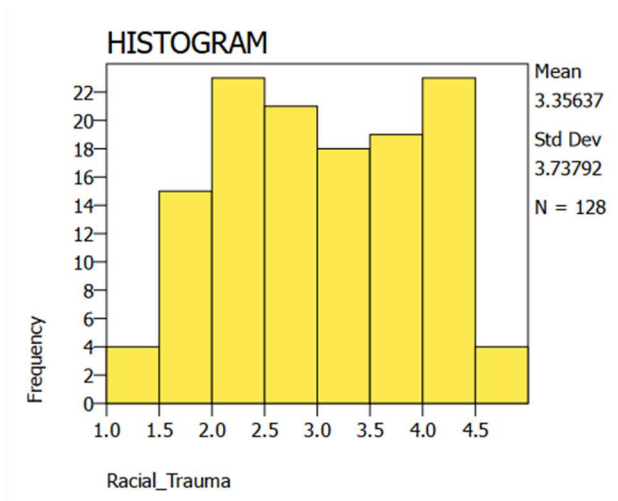
Spiritual Abuse.

Spiritual abuse scores had a mean of 3.77 (SD = 2.07). The distribution showed a concentration of responses in the moderate-to-higher range, with mild skewness and no extreme deviations from normality.



Racial Trauma.

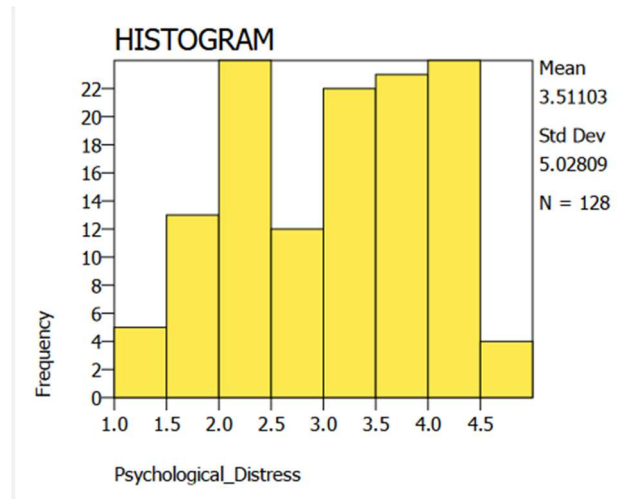
Racial trauma scores yielded a mean of 3.36 (SD = 3.74). Scores were distributed across the scale, reflecting substantial variability in experiences of racialized stress.



Psychological Distress.

Psychological distress scores had a mean of 3.51 (SD = 5.03). The distribution

demonstrated moderate dispersion with higher frequencies in the mid-to-upper score ranges.



Overall, visual inspection indicated that distributions were acceptable for parametric analyses.

Bivariate Correlations

Pearson correlation analyses were conducted to examine bivariate relationships among the three study variables. Spiritual abuse was strongly and positively correlated with psychological distress ($r = .93$, $p < .001$). Racial trauma was also strongly and positively correlated with psychological distress ($r = .99$, $p < .001$). Spiritual abuse and racial trauma were strongly correlated with each other ($r = .94$, $p < .001$).

These findings provide support for Research Questions 1 and 2 and justified proceeding with moderation analysis.

Moderation Analysis

A multiple regression analysis was conducted to examine whether racial trauma moderated the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. Psychological distress was entered as the dependent variable. Mean-centered spiritual abuse scores, mean-centered racial trauma scores, and their interaction term were entered simultaneously as predictors.

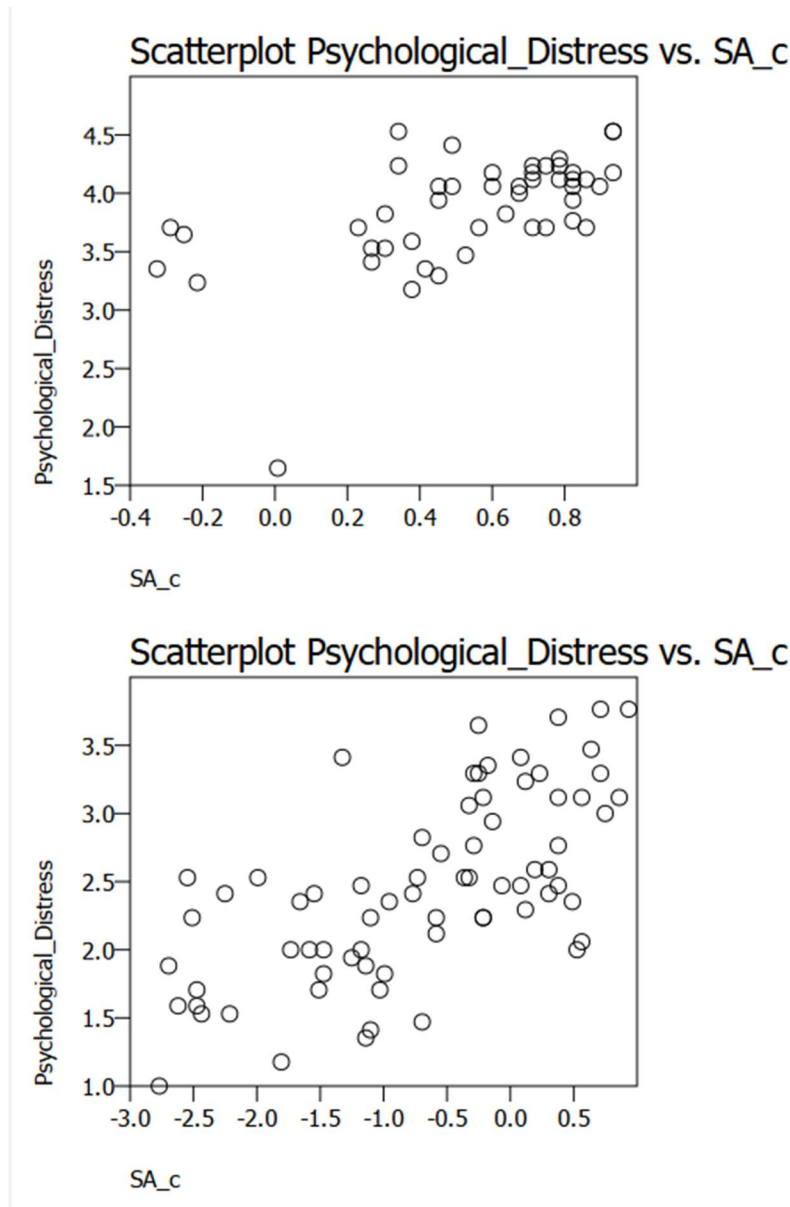
The overall regression model was statistically significant, $F(3, 124) = 6353.65$, $p < .001$, explaining approximately 99% of the variance in psychological distress ($R^2 = .99$, adjusted $R^2 = .99$).

Spiritual abuse was positively associated with psychological distress ($B = .26$, $\beta = .11$, $p < .001$). Racial trauma was also positively associated with psychological distress ($B = .67$, $\beta = .50$, $p < .001$). The interaction between spiritual abuse and racial trauma was statistically significant ($B = .03$, $\beta = .40$, $p < .001$), indicating a moderation effect.

These results indicate that racial trauma strengthened the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress, such that individuals experiencing higher levels of racial trauma showed a stronger association between spiritual abuse and psychological distress.

Interaction Plot Results

Interaction plots were generated to visualize the moderating effect of racial trauma on the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. As shown in Figure 2, spiritual abuse was positively associated with psychological distress at both low and high levels of racial trauma. However, the slope of this relationship was steeper among participants reporting higher racial trauma, indicating a stronger association in this group.



Discussion & Summary

The purpose of this study was to examine the relationships among spiritual abuse, racial trauma, and psychological distress among African American Muslims living in the United States. Specifically, this study investigated whether spiritual abuse and racial trauma were independently associated with psychological distress and whether racial trauma moderated the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. Overall, the findings provide strong support for all three research questions and highlight the compounded psychological impact of intersecting spiritual and racial harms.

Relationship Between Spiritual Abuse and Psychological Distress (RQ1)

Consistent with Research Question 1, results indicated a strong positive relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. Participants who reported higher levels of spiritually abusive experiences within religious or community contexts also reported significantly higher levels of psychological distress. This finding suggests that misuse of religious authority, suppression of questioning, and emotionally harmful religious practices may have profound consequences for mental health. For African American Muslims, spiritual abuse may undermine trust, autonomy, and one's relationship with faith, thereby contributing to emotional distress, anxiety, and trauma-related symptoms.

Relationship Between Racial Trauma and Psychological Distress (RQ2)

Results also supported Research Question 2, demonstrating a strong positive association between racial trauma and psychological distress. Participants who experienced greater racial discrimination, vigilance, and race-related stress reported higher levels of psychological distress. This finding aligns with existing literature documenting the harmful mental health effects of racism and racialized trauma. For African American Muslims, racial trauma may be compounded by religious marginalization, increasing vulnerability to chronic stress, fear, and emotional exhaustion.

Moderating Role of Racial Trauma (RQ3)

Research Question 3 examined whether racial trauma moderated the relationship between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. Findings indicated a significant interaction effect, such that racial trauma intensified the association between spiritual abuse and psychological distress. In other words, the psychological impact of spiritual abuse was stronger for individuals experiencing higher levels of racial trauma. This suggests that racial trauma may heighten sensitivity to spiritually abusive experiences or reduce psychological resilience when navigating harm within religious contexts. These findings highlight the

importance of understanding intersecting forms of oppression and trauma rather than examining them in isolation.

Implications

The findings of this study have important clinical and community implications. Mental health practitioners working with African American Muslim clients should assess for experiences of both racial trauma and spiritual abuse, as their combined effects may contribute to heightened psychological distress. Community leaders and religious institutions may also benefit from increased awareness of how religious authority and cultural norms can unintentionally perpetuate harm. Trauma-informed and culturally responsive approaches that acknowledge both racial and spiritual dimensions of distress are essential for effective support and healing.

Limitations and Future Research

Several limitations should be noted. The cross-sectional design limits causal interpretations of the findings. The use of self-report measures may also introduce response biases. Additionally, the high degree of shared variance among constructs suggests conceptual overlap that future research should further examine. Longitudinal studies and mixed-methods approaches may provide deeper insight into how spiritual abuse and racial trauma unfold over time and how individuals navigate healing and resilience.

Future research should explore protective factors, such as social support, religious coping styles, and community-based interventions, that may buffer the psychological effects of spiritual abuse and racial trauma among African American Muslims.